

Left Behind

Their expansionist efforts drawing a blank and traditional bastions slipping, the Communists will have to play a more subdued role



SIPRA DAS

For India's reds, who seem to have adopted the policy of obstructionism as their latest ideology, the Mood of the Nation poll holds little cheer. In the last four years, the Left parties provided the crutches but tried their best to ensure that the UPA Government did not move. The CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, at a news conference last week, gloated over having stopped the Government in its tracks on vital areas like FDI in retail and in insurance and banking, disinvestment in the Navratnas and profitable PSUs.

Our poll shows that for all this and much more that Karat left unsaid, the Indian voter may be unforgiving. His efforts aimed at expansionism having come to nought, Karat and fellow comrades will have to fall back on the Left's traditional strongholds of Kerala, West Bengal and Tripura. In Kerala, where CPI(M) and its allies won 19 of the 20 seats in 2004, the party is indulging in factional fratricide. That explains why, as our poll shows, the Congress which was shamed and ousted just two years ago has bounced back. In West Bengal, Nandigram is a blot that the party will find hard to remove. The reds don't matter in the rest of the country, but in the two states where they do, twice as many people believe that the events in Nandigram affected the party's credibility than those who thought otherwise. It appears for now that the Left's future is behind them.

by Ashok K. Damodaran

Do you think the Left is slowing down economic reforms?

39
(34)

YES

29

(26)

NO

*All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say.
Figures in brackets indicate
percentage in February 2007*

Even as the Left gloats over its success in stopping the Government from carrying out economic reforms, its efforts are not being viewed kindly by the people

What is your opinion on India being led by a coalition Government?

Good for India

31
2007

33

Bad for India

28

23

Neither good nor bad

26

-

*All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say*

What impact do you think Nandigram will have on the Left parties?

Will lose credibility

28

Will have no impact

27

Will improve credibility

8

*All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say*